
Movement Patterns for Daily Life

How you move through your day matters more
than what you do at the gym

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Inner Circle Deep Cut — #9

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Introduction

AN INNER CIRCLE DEEP CUT. HOW YOU ACTUALLY move through 16 hours of waking life — and why fixing your patterns matters more than any workout.

After 12+ years on the table, I've come to believe something most fitness culture misses: how you move through your daily life matters more than how you move during your workouts.

You exercise for an hour. You live the other 23 hours. The patterns you repeat during those 23 hours are the ones shaping your body. Sitting posture. How you stand at the counter. How you bend down to pick up your kid. How you carry groceries. How you walk. How you sleep. These patterns, repeated thousands of times per week, determine far more about your body's health and pain than any single workout.

You can have an excellent workout and still wreck your body if your daily movement patterns are bad. You can have a basic workout but maintain excellent daily patterns and your body will thrive.

This deep cut is about those patterns. Not workouts. Not exercise programs. The fundamental movements you do hundreds of times a day — and how to do them in ways that support your body instead of breaking it down.

CHAPTER 1

Why Daily Movement Patterns Matter More Than Workouts

THINK ABOUT THE MATH. YOU PROBABLY DO something like:

- Sit/stand at work: 8 hours per day
- Walk around home/errands: 1-2 hours
- Sleep: 7-8 hours
- Eat (often seated): 1 hour
- Misc daily activities (cooking, cleaning, parenting, hobbies): 4-6 hours
- Workout (if you do): 30-60 minutes

Even if you work out every single day for an hour, that's roughly 4% of your waking time. The other 96% is your daily movement patterns.

If your daily patterns are bad, no amount of workout can compensate. The 96% wins. You can't out-exercise hours of bad sitting posture, poor lifting mechanics, and asymmetric daily loads.

If your daily patterns are good, you don't need elaborate workouts to maintain function. The 96% is doing

the work. Workouts become a supplement, not a savior.

This is why I focus so much on the small daily patterns. Bending down to put on socks. Reaching for something overhead. Carrying a kid on one hip. Standing at the sink. These small repeated movements are where bodies are made or broken.

CHAPTER 2

The Fundamental Movement Patterns

HUMAN MOVEMENT REDUCES TO A SMALL NUMBER of fundamental patterns. Master these and most of life's physical demands become manageable. Lose them and even basic activities become difficult.

1. Hinge (bending from the hips)

Used for: bending down, lifting from the floor, deadlifting, sitting into a chair, picking things up.

Correct pattern: - Hips push backward - Knees stay relatively straight (slight bend) - Spine stays neutral (long line from head to tailbone) - The motion comes from the hip joint, not the lumbar spine - You should feel a stretch in the back of your hamstrings as you hinge forward

What goes wrong: - People bend from the lumbar spine instead of the hips - Spine rounds, weight shifts forward, low back takes the load - Common with sitting-dominant lifestyles where hip mobility is lost

Daily applications: - Picking up anything from the floor - Tying shoes (proper version: sit down OR hinge

with one knee on floor; bad version: stand and round forward) - Sitting down into a chair (hinge into it, don't fall into it) - Standing up from a chair (hinge forward to bring weight over feet, then drive up through heels)

2. Squat (lowering and rising)

Used for: standing up, sitting down, going to the bathroom, getting in/out of cars, gardening.

Correct pattern: - Feet roughly shoulder-width apart, slightly turned out - Knees track over toes (don't collapse inward) - Hips push backward and down - Chest stays relatively upright - Heels stay on the ground - Depth depends on individual mobility — going below parallel isn't required

What goes wrong: - Knees collapse inward (valgus collapse) — common pattern, hard on knees - Heels lift off the floor (ankle mobility issue) - Chest collapses forward (lacking hip mobility or core stability) - Low back rounds at bottom (insufficient hip mobility)

Daily applications: - Getting on/off the toilet - Getting in/out of low cars - Sitting on a low couch or chair - Reaching down to a low cabinet

Most people lose squat depth and quality over decades of chairs. Maintaining or rebuilding this pattern preserves significant functional capacity.

3. Push (pressing away from your body)

Used for: pushing doors open, push-ups, overhead pressing, getting up from the floor, anything that requires pressing.

Correct pattern: - Shoulder blades engaged and stable (not rolled forward or shrugged up) - Core braced - Pressing motion comes from the chest, shoulders, and arms working together - Maintain spinal alignment throughout

What goes wrong: - Pressing with rolled-forward shoulders - Compensating with low back arching - Hyperextending elbows or wrists - Loss of core stability during the press

Daily applications: - Pushing a shopping cart - Pushing doors open - Pushing yourself up from the floor or out of bed - Reaching to push something overhead onto a shelf - Push-ups (when done as exercise)

4. Pull (pulling toward your body)

Used for: pulling doors open, lifting things toward you, rowing, lifting bags, anything that requires drawing weight inward.

Correct pattern: - Shoulder blades retract (squeeze together) as you pull - Core stable - Pull comes from the upper back, not just the arms - Maintain spinal alignment

What goes wrong: - Pulling only with arms, not back muscles - Shoulders rounding forward during the pull - Lower back arching to compensate

Daily applications: - Pulling doors open - Lifting groceries out of the cart - Picking up bags - Pulling a child toward you - Pulling-style exercises (rows, pull-ups)

Most modern adults are push-dominant (we push more than we pull through daily life) and have weak pulling capacity. Adding more pulling activity (rows, pull-ups, even just being aware of pulling motions in daily life) balances this.

5. Rotation

Used for: turning to look behind you, reaching across your body, twisting motions, swinging a golf club, throwing.

Correct pattern: - Rotation should occur primarily through the thoracic spine (mid-back) - Hips can rotate too, depending on the motion - Lumbar spine should rotate minimally - Core stabilizes throughout

What goes wrong: - Mid-back is locked (can't rotate) → lumbar spine does the work it wasn't designed for - Rotation primarily through lumbar spine = strain on lumbar facet joints and discs over time

Daily applications: - Turning to look behind you while backing up - Reaching across your body - Put-

ting groceries away (reaching to a side cabinet) - Putting on a seatbelt - Looking around while walking

Most adults have lost significant rotation through the mid-back. See IC3 (Year of Your Mid-Back) for the deep dive on restoring this.

6. Gait (walking)

Used for: walking. Which is constant.

Correct pattern: - Heel strikes first - Roll through the foot to push off the toes - Hip extension behind you (your back leg extends fully) - Arm swing opposing leg movement - Slight rotation through the trunk - Head upright, gaze forward

What goes wrong: - Tight hip flexors prevent full hip extension behind you - Locked mid-back prevents normal trunk rotation - Foot strikes flat or on toes (different problems) - No arm swing (often from carrying things or holding phone) - Shuffling gait (very common in older adults — sign of mobility loss)

Daily applications: - Every step you take - Walking is the most-repeated movement most people do — pattern quality compounds

Maintaining good gait through aging is one of the strongest predictors of long-term physical function and independence. The bodies in their 80s who walk with normal gait are dramatically more functional than those who shuffle.

CHAPTER 3

How Most Adults Have Lost These Patterns

THE PATTERNS ARE INNATE TO CHILDREN. WATCH a 2-year-old squat — they have perfect form, deep range, easy mobility. Most adults can't replicate it.

What happens between childhood and adulthood:

Chairs

Hours of sitting per day, every day, for decades. The body adapts to the chair position. Hip flexors shorten. Glutes weaken. Mid-back locks. Squat depth disappears.

Schools and offices

We're taught to sit still. Movement is discouraged in formal settings. The patterns get suppressed.

Specialization

We do the same things over and over. Same desk position. Same workout pattern if we exercise. Same walk-

ing gait. Lack of movement variety leads to lost movement variety.

Sedentary culture

Cars instead of walking. Elevators instead of stairs. Apps that order things to your door. Less occasion for incidental movement. Less practice of fundamental patterns.

“Aging” myths

“My knees can’t squat anymore.” “My back can’t lift like it used to.” These often become self-fulfilling — we stop using the patterns, we lose them, we attribute the loss to age.

Specialized exercise

Even people who exercise often do it in patterns that don’t translate to daily life. Hour on a treadmill doesn’t restore squat depth. Bench press doesn’t restore mid-back rotation. Workouts can SUPPLEMENT daily movement patterns but rarely substitute for them.

CHAPTER 4

Pattern Self-Assessment

TEST WHERE YOU ARE ON EACH PATTERN. BE honest. The point isn't to judge yourself — it's to know what needs work.

Hinge test

Stand. Feet hip-width apart. Slowly hinge forward from your hips, keeping knees slightly bent. Reach toward the floor.

- ☐ I can touch my palms to the floor
- ☐ I can touch my fingertips to the floor
- ☐ I can reach mid-shin
- ☐ I can only reach my knees
- ☐ I can't bend over comfortably at all

Squat test

Stand. Feet shoulder-width apart. Slowly lower into a squat as deep as you can while keeping heels on the floor.

- ☐ I can squat with thighs parallel to the floor (or below) easily

- ☐ I can reach parallel but with effort
- ☐ I can get partway but not parallel
- ☐ I can barely bend my knees
- ☐ My heels lift off the floor when I try
- ☐ I can't squat at all comfortably

Get-up test

Sit on the floor cross-legged. Stand up without using your hands (if possible) and without holding onto anything.

- ☐ Easy — no support needed
- ☐ Possible but need one hand for support
- ☐ Need both hands
- ☐ Need to roll onto knees first
- ☐ Need significant help

This test is one of the strongest predictors of longevity and overall mobility. People who can do it well consistently outlive people who can't, controlling for other factors.

Rotation test

Stand. Feet planted. Cross arms over chest. Without moving hips, rotate slowly to the right as far as you can.

- ☐ I can see directly behind me
- ☐ I can see halfway behind me
- ☐ I can just see over my shoulder

- [] I can barely turn past my front

Gait observation

Walk past a window or have someone watch you:

- [] Normal heel-to-toe roll
- [] Mostly flat foot strike
- [] Shuffling (foot doesn't lift much)
- [] Pain or discomfort when walking
- [] Limp or favor one side

Carry test

Pick up something moderately heavy (a full grocery bag, a bag of dog food). Walk 50 feet with it.

- [] Easy, no compensation
 - [] Some leaning to the opposite side
 - [] Significant leaning or strain
 - [] Cannot comfortably do this
-

CHAPTER 5

Daily Practice to Reclaim Movement

PATTERN TRAINING DOESN'T REQUIRE SPECIAL equipment or extensive time. It requires regular practice of the patterns themselves.

Daily movement practice (10-15 minutes)

5 minutes hip mobility + squat work: - 10 slow bodyweight squats (or chair-supported squats if needed) - 10 deep lunges, alternating legs - 30 seconds in the deepest squat position you can hold (use a chair for balance if needed)

5 minutes hinge practice: - 10 slow hip hinges (no weight initially — just practice the pattern) - 10 reps of picking up something from the floor with proper hinge form - Slow standing forward fold, hang for 30 seconds (knees soft)

5 minutes spinal and shoulder mobility: - Open-book stretch from Bonus 4 (5 reps each side) - Cat-cow (10 reps) - Arm circles in both directions (10 each)

Daily movement awareness

Throughout your day, notice patterns:

Every time you sit down: Are you falling into the chair or hinging into it?

Every time you stand up: Are you using your hips and legs to power up, or pushing with hands?

Every time you pick something up from the floor: Are you hinging at your hips or rounding your spine?

Every time you reach overhead: Is your shoulder mobile? Is your mid-back contributing?

Every time you walk somewhere: Are you striding with normal hip extension? Or shuffling?

Awareness alone shifts patterns over time. You don't have to "do" anything special. Just notice. The body learns from attention.

Daily incidental movement

The other lever — make daily activities movement opportunities:

- Take stairs instead of elevators when possible
- Park further away
- Walk during phone calls
- Squat down to talk to children at their eye level

- Get on the floor to play with pets or grandchildren — practice the get-up
- Carry groceries instead of using carts when reasonable
- Stretch while waiting (in line, for water to boil, for kettle, etc.)

These add up to significant additional movement without any “exercise” framing.

CHAPTER 6

Activity-Specific Patterns

THE FUNDAMENTALS APPLY TO SPECIFIC COMMON activities. Here's how to do them well.

Sitting

- Don't sit on your tailbone — sit on your sit bones
- Feet flat on floor if possible
- Knees roughly level with hips
- Shoulders relaxed and back, not rounded forward
- Get up every 30-45 minutes minimum

Standing

- Weight even on both feet
- Knees slightly soft, not locked
- Pelvis neutral, not tilted forward or back
- Shoulders relaxed
- Don't stand still for long periods — shift weight, walk in place if you have to stand long

Lifting

- Get close to the object before lifting

- Hinge at your hips, not your back
- Lift with legs and glutes, not your back
- Keep the load close to your body
- Don't twist while lifting heavy objects
- For very heavy objects — get help, or accept that you don't need to lift them

Carrying

- Keep load close to your body
- Distribute weight evenly between hands when possible (two grocery bags rather than one heavy one)
- If carrying on one side, switch sides regularly
- Don't carry while walking long distances if you can avoid it

Reaching

- Reach with your whole body — let your shoulder, mid-back, and even hips contribute
- Don't over-reach by hyperextending your back or rounding your shoulders
- Use a step stool for high reaches instead of straining

Sleeping

- Side-sleeping with pillow between knees: best for most adults

- Back-sleeping with pillow under knees: also good
 - Stomach-sleeping: worst — forces neck rotation all night, arches low back
 - See Module 3 for full sleep mechanics
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CHAPTER 7

Tools and Aids

YOU DON'T NEED MUCH. MOST PATTERN TRAINING is bodyweight-based. A few useful items:

Worth owning

- **Yoga mat (\$20)** — for floor work, mobility practice
- **Sturdy chair** — for assisted squats and pattern practice (you probably already own this)
- **Door frame** — for doorframe stretches (everyone has this)

That's basically the entire required equipment list.

Optional / useful

- **Kettlebell or dumbbells** — once you have basic patterns, adding resistance can help
- **Light resistance bands (\$15)** — useful for shoulder mobility work
- **Foam roller (already covered in IC5)** — supports the mobility work

Not necessary

- Expensive functional movement equipment

- Specialized workout gear
 - Subscription fitness apps (unless they help you stay consistent)
 - Anything marketed as “transforming your movement in 30 days”
-

CHAPTER 8

When to Bring in a Professional

Bodywork (me)

- Tight tissue restricting your range of motion in specific patterns
- Recovery support
- Maintenance for someone doing significant pattern work

Physical therapist

- Recovering from injury
- Significant pattern dysfunction that home practice isn't resolving
- Post-surgical rehab
- Diagnosis of specific movement problems

Movement specialist / corrective exercise specialist

- Athletes wanting to refine specific patterns
- Significant chronic patterns that need professional eyes

- People past 60 wanting to systematically restore lost patterns

Doctor / orthopedist

- Joint pain during specific patterns
- Numbness or tingling
- Significant weakness
- Patterns getting worse despite practice
- Falls or balance issues

THE COMBINATION OF PROFESSIONAL INPUT (when needed) plus daily home pattern practice is more effective than either alone.

CHAPTER 9

Stories From the Table

“I do CrossFit five days a week and I’m still tight”

COMMON PATTERN. ATHLETES WHO TRAIN HARD but have terrible daily movement patterns. They squat heavy at the gym, then sit hunched at a desk for 8 hours, then drive home in a slumped position.

The intense training amplifies the issues from the bad daily patterns. They develop strength on top of dysfunction. Eventually something gives.

The fix: address the daily patterns first. The training becomes more effective when the body underneath isn’t compromised.

“I’m 45 and I can’t even sit on the floor”

A client came in distressed about realizing they could no longer sit cross-legged comfortably. They thought their joints were “going bad.”

Assessment showed it was hip mobility loss from decades of chair-sitting. Not joint damage. Just lost mobility.

Eight weeks of daily hip mobility work (couch stretch, 90-90 sits, squat practice) restored most of the comfort. The “joints going bad” was actually addressable function loss.

The lesson: most “I can’t do X anymore” stories are addressable mobility loss, not actual structural damage. Don’t accept the loss without trying.

“My mom shuffles and I’m afraid I’m starting to”

Powerful pattern observation. Gait quality is one of the strongest aging markers we have. People who maintain normal gait into their 80s consistently outlive and outfunction people who don’t.

The fix: hip mobility, hip extension specifically, glute strength, calf strength, walking with intentional good form. People who start this work in their 60s often regain normal gait. People who start in their 40s often never lose it.

The lesson: gait quality is a choice you make every day. Decline isn’t inevitable.

CHAPTER 10

What to Expect in a Year of Consistent Pattern Practice

MONTH 1-2: INCREASED AWARENESS OF YOUR patterns. Some immediate gains in mobility and ease.

Month 3-4: Daily incidental movements become easier. You don't think about "lifting properly" — you just do it.

Month 5-6: Functional capacity expands. Things you'd given up come back — sitting on the floor, deeper squats, easier overhead reaching.

Month 7-12: Pattern quality becomes the default. The body underneath your life moves better. Workouts (if you do them) are more effective. Daily life feels easier.

This compounds for the rest of your life. The pattern work you do at 45 pays dividends at 65. The pattern work at 65 pays dividends at 85.

CHAPTER 11

Closing

HOW YOU MOVE THROUGH YOUR DAY MATTERS more than what you do at the gym. The 96% of your time outside of workouts shapes your body far more than the 4%.

This document is your reference for those patterns. Read it. Reference it. Practice the patterns daily.

The bodies that thrive into older decades are the bodies whose owners maintained the fundamental movement patterns throughout their middle years. The fundamentals don't change. The needs don't change. The investment pays back for the rest of your life.

The companion workbook has a pattern self-assessment scorecard, a 30-day pattern practice tracker, and three reflection prompts to help you systematically rebuild your daily movement patterns.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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